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DESIGNING RELATIONS ALL THE WAY DOWN: *HYPERLOCAL ECO-SOCIAL* ARCS OF CARE AND ROLEPLAY

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ABSTRACT

We use the relational as a lens to examine how a workshop, created to inspire sensitivity to the interdependent nature of all life, is itself a nest of relations—shaped by intentions, co-created content, and outcomes beyond organisers' influence. With a practical mission to decentre humans and acknowledge interdependencies – in a turn to more-than-human ethics and a commitment to the *hyperlocal eco-social* – the workshop employs live action roleplay (LARP) to engage a small English town in facing future uncertainties. We explore the place of care, solidarity and collective agency in confronting readiness to deal with coming challenges. Linking theories of relationality and practices of relating, we conclude that the workshop can be an example of how, if we want meaningful change, locally-embedded agentic care relations can be made fractal through all our engagements and encounters.

INTRODUCTION

Can we design relations? Humans are relational all the way down, says Bendor (2025) writing about designing sustainability imaginaries (p3) – everything we do, learn and think is in connection. Language is relational. For example, anthropologist Strathern (2020) calls 'relation' a term that engages other terms: 'an idea that draws in values and disseminates feelings' (p2). Philosophers of technology (Verbeek, 2011) and design (Fry, 2010; Willis, 2006) show how design and social values not only relate but co-construct our worlds, evolving in parallel to each other. Every act of design is changing relations, wittingly or unwittingly, though little thought may be given to this in producing material matters.



Fig 1: Event invitation for *#This Coastal Town* workshop.

So, might we call "relational design" the work of turning people towards relations and their importance? Might it do the work of creating the conditions for better relations to exist? And what are these better relations? In this paper, we argue that the very act of noticing relations can lead to more care-full relations, because reflexivity and care are linked. And we propose that the act of drawing attention to relations in appropriate social settings can also strengthen productive relations in the immediate context. We describe this as *hyperlocal ecosocial* and elaborate upon it, below.

THEORETICAL POSITIONING

In considering the importance of *relational design*, there is the urgent ecological need to engage with the morethan-human, acknowledging the multiplicities and interdependencies that life depends upon, but which are written out of narratives of efficiency and progress. Relational design can be about what connects, or what Akama (2018) has called "ma", after the Japanese for the betweenness that fills what might otherwise be deemed empty space. Acknowledging these relations speaks to the care that extends between different bodies

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and constitutes systems. In this, *relational design* may be political and practical, representing a design that takes in the impact of actions on all life and asks practitioners to work carefully amongst the myriad entangled stories being lived.

Design as a practice of change-making is not then intrinsically flawed, but both process and outcomes must be held up to self-scrutiny to look for 'fecund' alternatives (Bardzell et al., 2021) to the capitalistcolonialist status quo. A focus on relations, such as designing with entanglement (Light et al., 2024a), care ecologies (Wilson et al., 2024), urban repair (Fjalland & Samson, 2019) or reworlding (Huybrechts et al., 2022), points to new cultures and imaginaries to be brought into being, inviting regeneration. When emphasis is placed on relationality (e.g. Escobar et al., 2024), it is associated with radical shifts in meaning, invoking unmaking (Lindström & Ståhl, 2020), participation otherwise (e.g. Botero et al., 2018), and inclusion that stretches beyond humans and beyond bodies in general to encounter spirit (Akama et al., 2020). It speaks from fluid, pluralist worlds that designers do not regularly inhabit, given the anthropocentric and functionalist (Bardzell et al., 2021) roots of design's (post)industrial (often-)commercial reality.

Nonetheless, we might argue that all design is relational, for it must link product and meaning, context and use, people and environment, etc. Clearly, *relational design* is itself relational – affected by who is practicing it and with whom, for what end and using which resources: any act of designing might be examined through this lens. Our contribution, then, is to use this lens to analyse care work—both in the process of designing and in its outcomes—to show that the relational is not fixed in a single relation to designing, but can be understood as fractal: it is relations all the way down.

To this end, we use a focus on relations (and changing them in ways intended to support all life) in multiple capacities to reflect on designing a *readiness* workshop (Fig 1) for a small coastal town, which we call *SmallTown* in this text. The workshop was used both to draw attention to and to build relations. Through this dual move, it was intended to maximally change relations. In creating the workshop, we also wove care through the design of the interaction to create conditions for change, as part of:

- identifying more-than-human interdependencies and exploring attempts to alter a neighbourhood's perception of these relations' importance;
- looking at the experience of workshop participants and the impact of care strategies to make them feel safer, allowing them to play harder and further;
- considering transformation in actions, to permeate the neighbourhood with a different ethos, which we might call 'eco-social' readiness (see Houston et al. 2022 for a detailed description of 'eco-social').

A WORD ON READINESS

Resilience is a familiar concept in sustainability circles (e.g. UNFCC nd). It is also associated with passing duties unilaterally from governments to individuals and families, such as handing over elderly care in the absence of municipal budget. It is thus linked with the adage 'what doesn't kill you, makes you stronger'.

Readiness aligns with meeting adaptation goals (in sustainability parlance, e.g. UNFCC nd) in that it recognises the change on the way, its uncertain impacts and the need to respond flexibly. Unlike some ideas of adaptation, it also emphasises the agency of the people affected, so that there is no hint of *nudge*, as there might be with top-down strategies. A person or group is aware they are ready; it is not a state to be handed on by other actors. At present, given global lack of leadership, many people feel that they are not ready for what the future may bring and are seeking means to gather to face coming uncertainties (which is also sometimes manifesting as a turn to right-wing demagogues).

So, *readiness* is understood for *SmallTown* as an agentic precursor (or alternative) to resilience and part of responding to physical changes in the environment (some which are particular to coasts) and social changes following failure to deal with current social and environmental crises (or the polycrisis, e.g. Hoyer at al. 2023). Importantly, what this means is not defined by outsiders, but by collectives of townsfolk.

#THIS COASTAL TOWN: METHOD

The workshop was created by Ruth of Furtherfield, an arts organisation establishing itself in a new – coastal – location, *SmallTown*, and Ann, an academic learning how immersive practices and live action roleplay (LARP) might support local readiness. It was devised on what we called a *hyperlocal eco-social* basis, such that: *co-located people are understood to share social and ecological matters of concern related to their environment and need a mechanism around which to cluster and move from individual concern to co-designed action that incorporates a lively appreciation of interdependencies*.

Ours was not the first activity using roleplay to consider place-based wellbeing. For instance, Harper (2022), with a theoretical contribution about habitus, uses the frame of resilience to focus tightly on particular places, including an orchard, and also advocates for 'stimulating the reflexive criticality of players' (np), while welcoming new habits forged in the action.

Our workshop explored the town's possibilities through LARP: an exercise in imagination with a process that asks people to adopt characters and take them into a fictional setting. LARPing is used for fun, and recently as a research tool (e.g. Bowman & Westborg 2024; Johansson et al. 2024; O'Brien et al. 2024). We use it

differently here, more akin to its educational uses (e.g. DeNeve & Heppner, 1997; Bowman, 2014; Hammer et al., 2018; Westborg, 2023; Bowman et al., 2024), with the goal of making change beyond the event. Judging the efficacy of this process requires observation in the moment and feedback from participants across time, with requisite analysis. We used debrief sessions and micro-phenomenological interviewing to gather data, with analysis of these for what they reveal about people's responses (following Light, 2006; 2008).

The horizons for judging effectiveness we chose were 1) how the workshop was received, 2) how it impacted on people's thinking and emotions in situ, and 3) how it plays out in place over months and years. While the last of these is not sufficiently mature, results for reception and impact have been very positive. This has led to a broader ambition: to abstract the best of the technique and try it in other contexts to judge transferability.

DESIGNING THE WORKSHOP

We first explain the design process, then turn to look at the arc of care that ran through how/what we designed.

Session 0: codesigning an embedding activity

Design took place through a series of collaborative events, mindful that key to LARP design is what participants create (Hernø, 2025) and that a collective approach that included town residents in thinking through priorities would allow us to keep this element creatively in play. In the first session, Ruth and Ann met to design a structure for establishing what might be of value to the town and to consider whether using an immersive event as a technique might work to address local futures. This planning session lasted two days and resulted in further activities.

Session 1: breakfast for the town to talk

An open invitation was extended to residents in *SmallTown* to come to breakfast and chat about the issues affecting the future of the town. In designing this encounter, we chose to focus on what people might wish to sustain (rather than on forthcoming loss) to keep people in a creative space, not least because previous experience suggested that when people are reminded of their frustrations, they tend to stay locked in critical mode, whereas groups made safe are able to give their imagination freer rein (e.g Montuori, 2011). Over the course of an hour, 18 people sat at one of four themed tables to talk on food, wellbeing, waterways, or culture, discussing futures, particularly for young people. The conversations sequentially addressed:
1. What would empower young people to make the town the best that it could be?
2. Things are always changing. What's important to sustain?
3. How does change happen in this place?

The session ended in cross-table discussions responding to the emergent concerns and we worked with these to look for the spaces and agents of potential change.

Session 2: reviewing the data

The core team of Ruth and Ann next met over transcripts of the themed discussions to cluster topics and choose a focus for a design workshop with young artists. We identified transcript excerpts that illuminated some major points in the discussion and used these as prompts in the next stage of the development process.

Session 3: more codesign

Taking priorities from the previous sessions and using a temporal tool (see https://lamemage.com/microscope/, a roleplay game for building alternative histories), we brought together three local artists for two days to brainstorm a structure and timeline for the town workshop. We settled on a 50-year local future and discussed possible landmarks in it. This session eliminated ideas as well as embracing them. For instance, by experimenting with the idea of sea otter personnel officers at the nearby Port, it was decided that, despite our more-than-human theme, no other beings would be actively in the roleplay – it would provide too much competition for the main theme and could make 'magic' outcomes more likely.

Using ideas from this workshop, we created a LARP and built a workshop process around it with devices for linking themes to roleplay and helping people move smoothly through.

Session 4: 2 x #ThisCoastalTown workshop

In September 2024, as part of a town heritage weekend, Ruth and Ann ran two sessions of *This Coastal Town Reimagined*, with an invitation to consider the future of *SmallTown*. The invite offered 'a fun morning or afternoon with your friends and neighbours, time-travelling into the future of this coastal town'. The workshops each involved 20 people for 2 hours.

People signed up without much sense of what they were going to be doing – they didn't know it would involve roleplay or environmental topics (though a full ethics process was followed at the event). The audience was local and diverse, with recruiting at a heritage weekend predicting openness to experience, but also a degree of randomness. For instance, two people wandered in who thought they were taking a town walk. Noone withdrew, though some decided at outset to reserve judgment about whether to stay. (One accompanying partner decided not to stay. He left on arrival, not experiencing enough to make a judgment based on content.)

THE STRUCTURES OF THE WORKSHOP

The workshop was designed for *SmallTown*, using a 200-year period – with a 150-year past and 50-year

future – to situate people in a flow of time and to support them in exploring changes from the heyday of the UK's major industrialised period of development on. First, people were asked to add events over the past 150 years from their own/family history and that of the town on a visual timeline (Fig 2) to set a rich context. Next, they were invited to discuss town employers and polluters as a way into ecological and economic issues.



Fig 2: The timeline invites consideration of industrialisation.

Then the future timeline becomes embodied in roleplay. This involves each participant developing a character. There is paraphernalia for this: they use a sheet with a choice of characteristics (such as *bossy, laid back, critical, optimistic*) and an open space for identifying the character's burning passion and an idea for a community initiative based on it. Each participant ends up with an 'alter ego' (though character development is not lengthy). It is consolidated by walking round the room and greeting others in role. Everyone is then asked to select a pebble, to be used as part of a ritual for bringing people in and out of role – enacting their change from self to a person in *SmallTown*'s future. The pebble supports their play: 'If you feel yourself slipping out of character (or out of the time) grab the pebble in your pocket. That is what it's there for. It represents the solid core of your character as we travel. It's there to remind you of who you are, and what you care about.'

In choosing a character, there are four life stages offered: child, young adult, mature adult, older adult. Participants select a starting point, then age as the play gets more distant, with the older adults coming back as the town's kids when a generation has elapsed. Ageing introduces notes of human ephemerality and gives a sense of travelling into in a further future for later scenes. (It also allowed for playing with the roleplay: in one session, we quipped, with reason, that the little girl looked just like her long-dead grandmother.)

There are three scenes. Ruth and Ann steer each in role as community leaders within the drama, allowing other participants to take their cue from the material provided in the introductory welcome we give at each point. The scenes are:

- a discussion about spending a small pot of community money for social and ecological wellbeing, set about 6 years into the future;
- a meeting about how a mysterious "Decade of Lost Summers" (an otherwise unspecified resonant placeholder for disaster – see below) impacted the town and how decisions were made that saw them through, about 25 years hence;
- a letter from 50 years into the future, detailing help they have given another small town struggling with some of the same coastal eco-social issues.

GETTING STARTED

We have designed an easy first stage to the roleplay for our participants' new characters. We set them in a community space a few years into the future, presenting a scenario in which the town has been offered money by the major employer/polluter to spend on social and ecological wellbeing. Each participant has, as stated, chosen a burning passion and derived a proposal from it for meeting a social and/or ecological community need. Just before beginning the roleplay, these proposals are shared and two are chosen, giving us a couple of characters to lead the action and advocate for them.

This mechanism has the merit of handing control to the group for the themes that people will discuss in the meeting about the community windfall. The device of the *burning passion* becomes a vessel to ensure that, although we provide the holding structure and prompts to keep the drama moving, the content of discussions is led by the curiosity and determination of participants and the themes they have selected.

The roleplay takes place and when ideas have been shared and negotiated in a lively but relatively straightforward scene of about 15 minutes, participants are asked to step out of role and take a moment to pause and fasten on things they find important in the scene just played so that they can remember them. And then the action steps forward into a second scene, about 25 years later, with a moment for age adjustments and the like, and we look back at that early meeting through the mists of the Decade of Lost Summers (hereafter Decade).

However, before sharing more detail of the action, we pause the workshop narrative here to return to describing the design and to reflect on how we created the more complex second part of the roleplay and why.

THE WORKSHOP'S RELATIONAL ARCS

From the outset, we knew that care for participants must run alongside their characters' projection into unknown futures. Benford and Giannachi's *trajectories* trace performance time to show how 'performances establish complex configurations of real and virtual, local and global, factual and fictional, and personal and social' (2022 np). Like us, they use the idea of story arc (e.g. Mckee, 1998), which identifies key points in moving through (fictional) events. However, the arcs to be traced in a co-located hyperlocal LARP are different to those in designing mixed reality (Benford & Giannachi, 2022): not only are there characters to consider as well as participants, but we were also intent on tracing postworkshop eco-social impacts. Strauss (1993, p53) calls 'trajectory' a course of action embracing 'the interaction

of multiple actors and contingencies that may be unanticipated and not entirely manageable' and Johnson et al. build on this: phenomena of interest appear through a 'complex interplay of intertwined trajectories that have varying durations and paces' (2010, p607). In making *This Coastal Town Reimagined*, we found several arcs to consider, each with a bearing on the relational and each trajectory with a different duration and pace:

- The **temporal** arc of past to future (Fig 2) sets the agenda for what we are asking people to engage with. The timelines relate present dilemmas to a broader context of pasts, futures and impacts.
- During the roleplay, the temporally-spaced future scenes through which we take characters produce the **story** arc, working sequentially and in contrast to each other, and potentially building a drama.
- The **workshop** has its own narrative: embedding the story arc in the designed engagement of the whole session, including onboarding, preparing the characters, debriefing and wrapping up.
- The design of the session includes **care** for participants that has its own arc, reflecting our responsibility for strangers meeting together to engage, on these themes, by our design. This arc is active during the roleplay (and wider workshop), but extends beyond both into participants' lives – intended to be motivational (or at least free of incapacitating or damaging emotions) once people leave, as well as during group interactions.
- Relatedly, there is an individual/collective arc of experience for participants which leads beyond the workshop to what might follow. Is this a learning arc? Is it an arc of **transformation** for the person, the collective and/or the place?
- The workshop is merely one possible way of honouring local issues, promoting change and maintaining a caring presence, so there is a longer arc of **development** in *SmallTown* with leadership or participation from more townsfolk.

We cannot stipulate how these latter three arcs come to a finish as we can with the stages of a workshop – our horizon of influence is not clear. But we have questions that help us understand these arcs and whether we have created motivational conditions: Will people respond to any issues raised? Do the trajectories fade or stay vivid? Will solidarity continue? Are new eco-social/more-than-human pathways for change being created because of participating? And what is a meaningful duration to measure in judging the workshop's impact?

THE ARC OF CARE

Much of what is relational in our descriptions lives in our ambition to raise awareness of interdependencies and build solidarity between participants. Part of this could be enacted through the structures we built but it also hung on our relationship with participants in facilitating – together they reflect our duty of care as designers. This section deals with that arc of care, how we built in a meta-narrative around the workshop and how that affected our narrative design, including the "timing" of events. We call it an 'arc' because it develops, evolving in parallel to the story arc of the fictional action and beyond.

It is now well-known that forcing people to consider environmental disaster can be counter-productive. They can become anxious, disheartened or go into denial. This means that concepts raised during the workshop (by organisers or others) might be distressing and linger in people's minds in unhelpful or traumatic ways. Yet it would be absurd – and possibly unethical – to present a future for *SmallTown* that did not touch on climate change, less predictable weather patterns, rising seas and coastal erosion, as well as possible ingroup-outgroup hostility, failing leadership, changing employment possibilities and political polarisation.

Our responsibilities lay in two directions. First, our participants had walked into the workshop with no expectation of experiencing content that might be distressing. We had indicated that we would be discussing change: 'things are always changing here and in the wider world' (text in invite), but not that they would be confronting the major predicament of our time. Activities concerning town futures are not always attentive to these contextual aspects; in fact, they are often left out as externalities (Shareable 2018).

Further, we were using LARP, a technique that engages people differently than news media or other information sources might. LARPing is designed to bring in emotions and 'live through' dramatic experience, even if this is handled through the mechanism of adopting an alter ego. (In fact, it is argued - see Munier 2021- that acting as someone else allows for more engagement and more risk-taking.) Safekeeping is often an important part of LARPing, not least because the structure brings strangers together in emotive situations and both elements can lead to stress or worse in what is supposed to be enjoyable play (e.g. Holkar 2016). Furthermore, we could expect people to react with aspects of their usual selves 'bleeding' into their character—and, crucially, vice versa (e.g. Huugas 2021). Thus, rather than assuming compartmentalized emotions, we recognised their transferability. This heightened both the responsibility of preventing misery during those two hours (and beyond) and the challenge of doing so.

Second, given our agenda was to support *SmallTown* in developing its readiness (itself intended as an act of care), we could not shy away from emotive issues and anxiety-creating impacts. We had to allow for these to arise and encourage their discussion in a responsible and caring manner, with a stretch goal that this would

inspire desire in participants to continue working together. So, our design started with care and worked outwards to provide something that could delight and inspire, even in the midst of a potentially horrifying scenario. We could not downplay crisis, but we could play up solidarity and agency in the face of it and give people something to hold onto.

GENERAL TECHNIQUES OF CARE

The rationale for establishing ground rules for comfort and safety in group play is well documented and can be managed in diverse ways (e.g. Mel, 2015; Holkar, 2016). In planning, we discussed co-creating ground rules for behaviour during the workshop, but settled upon individual briefings as part of onboarding participants and then setting up constructive discussion - first on the history of the town and later, in role, about assigning funding – as a way of managing interactions.

We also used techniques to keep action light and easyto-handle, while serious. For instance, we included humour: written into the early interplay between Ruth and Ann (in role) was a familiar dynamic of bossy community leader and slightly tentative assistant. Though not exaggerated for comedy, this touch added some dramatic content at the outset—something participants could effortlessly enjoy. (In later scenes, the community leader returns as a quizzical child, then a young adult at the end, and the dynamics between the facilitators change, to avoid cliché.)

There are biscuits [cookies] brought round in a slightly uncertain way by the assistant as an opening to the first in-role action, which is the meeting to consider spending community money. This gives everyone a chance to 1) share food (an act of imbibing care) and 2) show off their character to others with a simple task as they first step into role. We used vintage biscuits to play on temporality, serving to remind people of 'younger days', while allowing us to future-proof a near-future for which we could not predict changes in fashion.

LIVING A DECADE OF LOST SUMMERS

Returning to the workshop narrative, we can consider the remainder through this lens of care. Perhaps the main work of care - as we moved through the arc from early reassurance to encouraging new perspectives - was the design and placing of a predicament. The predicament we needed had to be significant enough that the group knew there were difficult times for *SmallTown*, but not so devastating emotionally that they were overwhelmed – or paralysed. As mentioned, the Decade (of Lost Summers) stood in for something disastrous and long-lasting, with little clue provided as to what it was. We chose not to explain the Decade, using it as a device for participants to project upon as characters who have experienced it. In this way, it became a repository for participants' predictions and fears, sharing the uncertainty of future disruptions as they improvised.

Importantly, in the LARP, the Decade is introduced to the characters as something that they have endured and can now reflect upon. Our key decision, motivated by the linked concerns of effectiveness and protection, was that, as well as having a long and terrible period of struggle dominantly in the middle of the exercise, we would set the encounter with it as something participants' alter-egos only encounter retrospectively. Characters never experience it directly. By temporally placing the Decade as a recently endured historic phase, rather than an occurring event, participants are protected from having to directly inhabit the horror of the period. This way, they can make up accounts of how they managed the situation without having to bring into their bodies the worst of it. This makes safe, but also positions people with maximum creative agency – they coped and they can now explain how. We set the scene in a hall, with 'young adults' and 'children' asking 'mature adults' what the Decade was like to live in and how they made it to the other end. In the process, 'mature adults' volunteer to explain, adding ideas as they go along. The format encourages the telling of tales of significant destruction and survival, but also stays grounded as the questions to come are known to involve answering *how* they got through and what they learnt.

Clearly, participants are finding resourceful answers to coming problems in answering these questions. It was also at this point in both sessions that interdependencies with non-humans started to appear in the narrative - and as a discussion of other beings in their own right. We didn't introduce this theme; it is notable that it emerged naturally. Listening to the accounts of surviving the Decade, there is a shift here: evidently, from what characters said, it was impossible to get through the Decade in *SmallTown* without extending care to other species and considering material more-than-human questions such as what people and livestock now ate. While no one mentioned this shift themselves, for us, monitoring themes while leading the action, it indicated a change in the inclusiveness of considerations and the remit of care and was therefore a marker for us of maturing thought about relations, as well as creativity.

A SPACE FOR REFLECTION AND CONNECTION

Another element, which is common across LARPs and experiential learning contexts, is a period for debriefing after the roleplay– we allocated nearly 30 minutes. In LARPs, this is often a chance for players to meet together and give feedback to the organisers, and also to de-role – i.e. to put your character behind you. It is accepted that there may be 'bleed' between feelings in and out of character, but de-roling minimises it (e.g. Huugas 2021). It is a time to help people process what they have experienced so they do not stay stuck in role.

But, in educational drama practice, collective processing is also used to encourage a change of perspective by allowing experience to be interpreted and integrated, making it accessible as learning (Johnson & O'Neill 1984). As well as this potential for change, we had a *hyperlocal* goal: to let participants hear each other and find common mission as people living in the same small town. The relation between individual and collective action is never wholly transparent, but in terms of next steps, peer connections could be important.

Thus, our process of designing stages for the workshop and for the roleplay within it (so that the story arc offered maximum agency, learning and sharing and minimum embodied horror and distress) was an act of care that foregrounded acts of care as a theme for all.

RECEPTION/IMPACT OF THE WORKSHOP

We turn now to evaluation. As part of assessing impact, Ann interviewed several participants from each session about their experience after the workshop finished or on the following day. She asked for a chronological account of the experience in the interviewee's own words, using the retrospective method outlined in Light (2006; 2008). This style of interviewing does not solicit judgment but description, to find out what is recalled as a test of salience. This is related to what Nowacki and Stasiak (2025) call 'memorable game experiences' in analysing the immersive context of escape rooms. When accounts of changed feelings and speculation about possible future behaviour do emerge in Light's style of interview, they are notable because they are unsolicited by questioning.

We quote a section of a participant interview by way of illustration, observing the positive feeling the workshop sounds to have inspired in her, as well as the heightened sociality she reports and the significance of the local nature of the group ('paths will cross'):

E: 'I had a couple of really nice conversations with people on my way out and outside. It felt like I had a connection with people in a different way that I wouldn't have had if I hadn't had that experience with them. It's almost like I felt even more connected than I would if I'd just met them. […] Oh, what is the feeling? It felt quite exciting and energizing and not… I had no sense of like social anxiety. It felt like a really good way in to connecting with people. I felt like I saw something about them, and they saw something about me.

'Normally, you know… you see, you get stuck on the level of small talk and not get beyond that. […] I just felt like, "Oh, yeah, we had this experience together, and now I feel like if I meet you again …when I meet you again, because I'm sure paths will cross at some point…" I don't know, there's like a warmth. An energy. Yeah, a sense of excitement and possibility.'

Also unsolicited, we found that the project had been linked on social media, with a posting by a local group: 'We want to offer a massive 'Thank you!' to Ruth and Ann for their excellent interactive workshop earlier today on *This Coastal Town Reimagined*. The workshop was imaginative, insightful and challenging. We can immediately see how […the…] work can have practical application. We look forward to further collaborations.'

Another local resident assured us that there would undoubtedly be action taken as a result. And not only did people who wandered in decide to stay, but they participated fully in the debrief and told us afterwards that they had very much enjoyed the event and it had made them think about things differently, though they were not forthcoming about how.

We had been keen to bring interdependencies into play in an experiential way. We wanted people to *feel* that life is contingent on both the functioning of the greater planet and the cogs in the systems around them, such as food production and photosynthesis. During the reflection session, there were some references to these types of connection. For instance, K called the experience 'light and engaging […] but dealing with big issues and beginning to explore the visions', and L said: 'It's really made me realise, how planning now is so important to how we do actually cope with climate change.' Both show they were applying their encounters with the local situation to a wider context. The more-than-human in people's accounts was less evident: neither the sea nor other species became a focus.

RECEPTION OF ROLEPLAYING

In answer to the impromptu direct question "Would you have participated if you had known there was roleplay involved?", the answer from almost everyone was an emphatic 'no'. Nonetheless, comments in the reflection session included positive reaction to this technique, as did follow-up questions:

B: 'I would like to spend the whole day inhabiting the character […] because [of] the relationship building and playful practice in this type of activity, for me, and potentially others. We could really benefit from further exercising imagination.'

M: 'I think it was nice to have that other character that you are. It's hard sometimes being yourself. Whereas you feel like you can just express yourself more in different ways, and maybe be a bit more like... and also it's just a bit more enjoyable... making up that character and having the whole picture in your head. … This was a great opportunity to share ideas through the front of a different character, to remove the fear of being judged for their own opinions.'

M is describing something known in LARP circles as 'alibi', the chance to try out modes of being as part of roleplay that, for one reason or another, you do not have

permission for in everyday life. This feature has transformative opportunities associated with it: hearing your mouth make commitments about care may be surprising to you, but it may also 'bleed' into who you become. Later, some reported that holding a pebble was a comfort in role and some took "their" pebble home, suggesting another form of attachment.

DISCUSSION

In this paper, we have presented the development arc of the workshop, linked to arcs of care and transformation. The work is the culmination of a year of planning and collaboration. It marks one endpoint to the research and a time of reflection for the core partners. However, inspired by our experience, we are intending to continue to test the parameters of usefulness for the material.

As part of this research, we are seeking to understand the dynamics. As noted above, the lens of the relational allows us to consider the process of designing the workshop in tandem with its effects and with the content generated, as a series of moves existing in relation to each other and to the outcomes we sought. But even identifying what the workshop *is* can be tricky. For instance, the content – the product of a group improvisation created by diverse people with little in common but locality – is not reproducible, even if we use the same prompts and structures repeatedly. We can identify several types of co-created material: 1) the workshop's focus, 2) its topics and 3) the group's interactions. These are things that we created the conditions for, but, by leaving space for participants'/ characters' agency (which was largely the point), the workshop could only emerge through group process and might be different every time. Thus, we can only say that the workshop is unpredictable yet responsive: that it provides opportunity for an increased sense of agency. The *relational* lens helps us see that we need to look at outcomes, not in terms of the workshop content, but of our agenda of inspiring *post-workshop* change and judging our premise that there is a practical link between tighter social relations and the potential for acting on greater appreciation of interdependencies.

MEETING OUR AGENDA

Workshop outcomes were intended to be stronger bonds between local people and greater awareness of relations as a precursor to supporting care for a wider franchise of beings. *Noticing relations,* with a change in individuals' understanding, needs a collective home for action. Local networks could become responsible for rethinking species relations and promoting this with others in their locality The 'readiness' of solidarity is not to be separated from awareness of why interdependencies are crucial to a thriving future, which shows how entangled matters become in this kind of work. Both solidarity and reflexivity are needed for (a change to) thriving life and wellbeing. Nonetheless, for research purposes, we tease these elements apart to judge each for its contribution to the whole. We can ask a series of evaluative questions:

Did our workshop inspire participants to consider the uncertainties of the future and the need to get ready? Extensive interviews (of an hour or more) suggest that the workshop achieved this in its immediate context, though we have yet to evaluate impact over time. The longer study is made complicated by questions of how to understand the workshop's influence and when to ask for evidence.

Did we generate stronger community relations through our workshops? The feedback suggests we did. This was not merely that people met, but that the quality of connection was made different by engaging (see, for example, excerpts from E's interview). We can ask if it is possible to change the fabric of the town, one group at a time. Beyond the connections that come from participating together, will there be *inter*-workshop recognition of some shared experience of process between the groups that did the workshop? Might a feeling across the town build through many groups handling similar material? We have yet to explore this.

Were people more aware of more-than-human interdependencies as a result of participating? Relationships described in the roleplay suggest this was the case, but participants did not explicitly refer to more-than-human factors in the debrief or interviews. We are not sure how much influence the experience has if it stays in the space of the narrative (i.e. possibly subliminal). Does *noticing* need to be noticed? If, in future, we ask about this in debriefing, results will be impacted by our surfacing of it. Handling this could be an area for inquiry when we run later workshops.

Did the arc of care support experiences to flow beyond the workshop and enable other outcomes? Yes, to the extent that we could identify meeting the goals above. What we do not know is if we might be more effective with another type of engagement and whether more or different care might produce results with more focus on multi-species relations.

We might ask if we made a good LARP. Stenros and Montola (2010) describe some criteria: 'Every single game portrayed in this book was born out of a desire to make the most powerful, the most interesting or the most novel larp possible.' (p10). Our aspirations were more modest and focused on what LARP techniques enable. While indisputably involving 'live action roleplay', our artistry, such as it was, had different ends.

ARCS AS CONNECTORS

Returning to the definition of trajectory as a course of action which embraces 'interaction of multiple actors' and 'may be unanticipated and not entirely manageable' (Strauss 1993), we can see some aspects that we

deliberately allowed to diverge and grow (the LARP themes; people's characters; the nature of The Decade) and others where we designed to manage the sprawl (focus on local agency; coastal issues; safeguarding) with a goal of inspiring and directing transformation, not good story-telling for its own sake.

We put care, rather than content, central so that beyond the role of planetary care as the wider *theme* of the work, it also underpinned the *design* of the experience itself. It is not intuitive to lead with care rather than narrative, but care was the bridge between experience and the wider goal. What we have called the 'arc of care', linking an experiential arc for participants to the *story arc* that we devised, is also linked to *the arc of transformation,* the possibility that the workshop influences people to make change. Modelling care, agency and solidarity in the workshop alongside the story strengthens those as possible pathways to change. It also meant that our practice was congruent with the action we invited people to perform in the workshop - and after. We have not described the last stage of the roleplay, which was simply the public reading of an affirmative letter, set in 2075, that cemented the idea of the town having taken regenerative action. It was part of the general balancing act between seeding the idea of successful adaptation and acknowledging the troubles encountered by the town over 50 years, both of which we hoped to leave lingering in minds of participants.

WHAT WE LEARNT

In the next sections, we reflect on what our experience taught us and what else might be desirable in working with this structure. A first learning was the relevance of the LARP form for participatory, collaborative and emergent anticipatory design and for managing an inclusive process, mindful of the need to democratize futures (e.g. Light, 2021). It turns out LARPing can be tuned to exploring and situating agency, alongside understanding and action. As a method, it lends itself to both experimenting and reflection, making it a good vehicle for imagining change and integrating outcomes.

PRACTICAL ACTIONS

To give the best chance of collective co-influence and take-up, we made a point of working locally - all the creators and participants except Ann were of the area. By working so (hyper)locally, we planned that people could easily find each again. Roleplaying readiness in the place that one wants to be ready makes for relevance as well as connection; further events could be held for the same or similar constituencies.

Yet there is possibly more at stake. We recognise that many localities can benefit from rehearsing a situation where the community secures funding from powerful actors around them, such as employers and/or polluters. In *SmallTown,* the major employer is the major ocean polluter - a well-known economic/ecological tension. This creates a dynamic for discussion, particularly in this first scene (deciding what to do with a community windfall from the polluter), and that has value for the roleplay. Further, in reflecting if there is actionable learning to be gathered from this imagined encounter, Boal's *Theatre of the Oppressed* (2017) comes to mind. Our work resembles Boal's in offering structures that support groups to rehearse change ahead of potentially making it. Perhaps, then, this first scene is not only a chance for ideas to be aired and for people to establish their roles. It may also be a rehearsal for taking this action in support of readiness: inventing and trying out eco-social plans that might help justify a request for funding and doing so in a group that could take such an action forward. Such a suggestion might mitigate the post-workshop frustration of wondering what to do next – it presents at least one possible next step.

INTERDEPENDENCIES IN TIME, IN PRACTICE

To generalise from the last point, one important element introduced by taking people into the future is that, on some level, their work there becomes real. It is lived experience and this changes its status. It lives in the body as something that has happened and, when it goes well, it supplies the benefit that accompanies past success – a sense of how to tackle it again next time. People have heard their mouth utter a plan or feeling and that cannot be undone, even if it is forgotten.

It is understood that LARPs teach people things about themselves and how they might relate to the world (described on multiple dimensions by Bowman and Huugas 2021; Baird et al. 2022), though what is learnt is open and emerges through interaction as much as by design. One cannot say that experiential learning is dictated by materials or exchanges – it has the 'unanticipated' quality that Strauss speaks of (1993). And the learning trajectories that people follow in group settings are particularly prone to the impact of other actors and contingencies - and their unmanageability (ibid): with 'complex interplay of intertwined trajectories that have varying durations and paces' (Johnson 2010). However, the branch of roleplay that is used in educational contexts does anticipate outcomes – edu-LARPs and simulations have specific educational goals (e.g. DeNeve & Heppner 1997; Bowman 2014; Hammer et al. 2018; Westborg 2023; Bowman et al. 2024), as did educational drama (e.g. Johnson & O'Neill 1984), which used what is now known as live action roleplay to teach curriculum. We see the *This Coastal Town Reimagined* workshop to be in this same tradition in its stated awareness-raising ambitions. We are using what 'make-believe' is good for as a learning tool – challenging, inspiring and connecting.

MORE-THAN-HUMAN(S)?

We suggest some new associations were made. The importance of other species and other ways of living emerged through suggestions for how people had had to live when ecological disaster hit them. There was evidence that people said things in role and then realised that these changes were needed and possible. This was apparent during the play though not so much caught in reflection (as noted above). With the insight that people may act first and realign their values second, contrary to some of our intuitions, this order - of making it up and then finding the truth in it - could be applied to reflect on relations with other species.

There was, running through the action, awareness of other life, the threat of the water and the opportunity of the seaweed forests that grow just beneath the ocean's surface. But, in considering human-world relations and the neglected importance of the more-than-human – which was a major motivation for us – we were not left sure how far our workshop explores respect for other life or hinges on the presence of the sea. The benefits of seaweed were talked about as carbon sinks and food; there was little talk of other sea creatures. Characters expressed concern for farm animals; the damage done to small creatures from melting road surfaces; and the impact of major housing development plans, which are running across the UK at present. All of these concerns are less coastal in nature. We found ourselves asking if there is value in roleplaying readiness more broadly.

CAN THE WORKSHOP TRANSFER?

This brings up the question of whether we have something that, while not scalable (either in participant numbers, or in the size of locality), is transferable and might spread. We had assumed that the *hyperlocal eco-social* nature of the workshop meant that it could not be applied in other places – social and environmental conditions being very specific. We wrote the workshop for *SmallTown*. It is unlikely that it could work the same way in somewhere bigger where the idea of the place is less coherent (*SmallTown* is about 25,000 people). But perhaps we can find similar concerns to those of *SmallTown* in other small (coastal) towns, making the activity meaningful elsewhere. After some tweaking, next steps are to work out how to genericise the mechanisms, while creating opportunities for other people to customise the details that make it feel relevant to a particular spot. We can then invite other organisers to run *This Coastal Town Reimagined* in their locations.

CHOICES THAT WORKED

As a starting point to producing a reproducible account of the design choices we made, we can think through a few of the elements that 'worked' here. As noted, the first may be the adoption of LARPing for tackling readiness and for thinking through relations. We were using it as a political form as well as a series of techniques. We chose to engage broadly across the town, treading lightly with difficult subjects to leave participants powerful rather than frightened, despite (and because of) the need for sustained action. We built a platform through collaborative storytelling for participants to build on further. As 'E' suggests, the shared experience left uncharacteristically warm feelings in its wake and gave an air of excitement.

We gave people space, through roleplay, to negotiate relations. We allowed people to share predictions about the future of their town and its vulnerability to future crisis, but we situated that future in the past so residents could look back and use in-role reflection for coming up with tactics and taking confidence about getting through the worst. We concentrated on these dynamics rather than playing with more sustained other-species encounters such as those using roleplay for sensitisation elsewhere (e.g. Clarke et al., 2019; Light et al., 2024b). This avoided promoting 'magical' thinking where a difficulty is overcome by, for instance, deciding that the Port might in future be run by sea otters or fish.

We developed other sensitising devices, such as a visual timeline to bring in the UK's industrial past and connect the local with the global, while keeping the exercises' focus at the hyperlocal level and full of relatable detail.

LIMITATIONS

We learnt that some of our techniques were successful for this place and time, at the point of sampling. Yet, we have only tried the workshop in *SmallTown* and, though we built on facilitation experience elsewhere to design it (Ruth writes LARPs as part of her practice and Ann is experienced in using design, drama and experiential learning together), we can surely improve it. For instance, we can do more to make the transition back into everyday life likely to result in action towards being 'ready', i.e. work on the arc of transformation. Nonetheless, is not an experiment and every group is intrinsically different, even in the same place and with the same facilitators. All we can do is help prepare a version that can be attuned for each place and facilitation team that works there. It will then be possible to compare experiences and use professional judgment (Goodman et al., 2011) to create a stable frame for it or a suite of variations for different contexts. Even then, execution will always reflect the emphasis of particular facilitators and facilitation styles as well as the nuances of place, while, of course, the action that ensues will be unrepeatable, as we discussed earlier.

This serves as a reminder that plays of agency remain complex with any creation of this kind, especially given the use of emotive techniques for purposes of influence. The workshop is designed to promote (a sense of) agency, but that very choice sits beyond the scope of the workshop's collective decision-making. The choice to

create the workshop is one that Ruth and Ann made, bringing their own concerns. The only choice for *SmallTown* residents in this respect is whether to join the workshop or not – giving us yet another reason for emphasizing a relation of care, even as we acknowledge our entanglement in the interdependence of relations.

CONCLUSIONS

Strathern (2020) suggests that attempts to address the *relational* quickly get lost in the diffuseness of the term. 'Seemingly, it has to be qualified to be useful, …[yet], there is no point in wishing the ambiguities away' (p1). We have tried, as makers and authors, to balance the ambiguities of relational design with a concrete example of work attending to relations. In doing so, we have become twisted in the complexities of using a relational lens to draw attention to the interdependencies not just of life, but of the design of structures that seek to embed a different ethos in the places that surround us and from which new human-world relations may arise. But, for us, theories of agency and relation must form the basis for actions on the ground – to practice the philosophies of life we want to live by. In striving to regenerate futures, we approach decentring humanity to move practically *from individual concern to co-designed action with a lively appreciation of interdependencies.*

This is part of our 'hyperlocal eco-social' roleplay. And we aspire to give qualities of *care* the pre-eminence that future design requires of them – a prefigurative relation entangled here to be recognised as the foundation of all meaningful connections. In this paper, we have sought to play out this care through describing the design choices in making a tool for supporting others' agency. The contradictions in such action have been aired. Yet, the relationality made prominent in discussing *relational design* asks us to go beyond anticipating futures to consider who (and what) chooses futures, as well as what those choices could be.

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